

SUPPLY-CHAIN DISRUPTION BRIEF

The Strait of Hormuz has been closed to container ships since March

A separate shock from the Red Sea crisis: the 2026 Iran conflict shut the entrance to the Persian Gulf, and box-ship transits have run near zero for six months.

By Michael Schertz Tooling **logjam** (open-source) Generated 2 Sep 2026 Source IMF PortWatch
Method see § Method & provenance

HORMUZ CONTAINER TRANSITS 7 % of normal 1.0/day now vs 15 pre-crisis	CONTAINER CARGO CAPACITY 4 % of normal Capacity fell as hard as the vessel count
JEBEL ALI CONTAINER CALLS 18 % of normal The Gulf's main box hub, effectively offline	ONSET Mar 2026 Distinct from the 2023 Red Sea crisis; no recovery trend

§ 1 The finding

Container-ship transits through the Strait of Hormuz have run at roughly **7% of normal** since March 2026 – the Persian Gulf's box trade has effectively stopped.

This is the **2026 Strait of Hormuz crisis**, not the Red Sea one. Different chokepoint, two years later: the Red Sea / Houthi disruption (late 2023) diverted the Asia–Europe route around Africa; the Iran conflict (March 2026) closed the entrance to the Persian Gulf.

IMF PortWatch counted **15 container transits per day** through Hormuz in the clean quarter of late 2023, and the level was steady at about 16 per day through 2025. Since March 2026 it has averaged **under one per day** — 1.0 in July. Container cargo capacity through the strait is at **4% of normal**. The collapse is uniform across classes — tankers are at **9%**, total transits at **11%** — the signature of a route-wide closure, not a commodity-specific restriction.

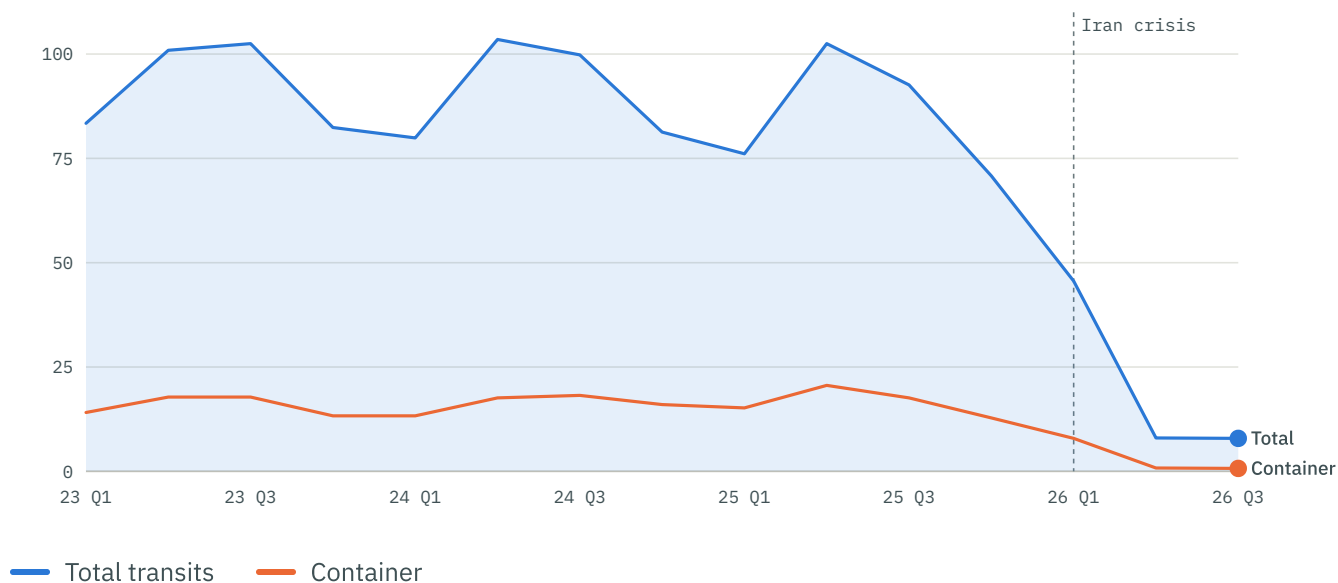
§ 2 Stable for three years, then a wall

Hormuz traffic is normally seasonal but flat year to year. Container transits held between roughly 13 and 21 per day every quarter from 2023 through 2025 — the 2023 Red Sea crisis, visible as a cliff in the Suez and Bab el-Mandeb data, left Hormuz untouched, because the Gulf oil trade does not use the Red Sea.

Then the line falls off the table in the first quarter of 2026 and keeps falling into the second. There is no recovery trend through late August.

Strait of Hormuz transits per day — total vs container

Quarterly average, 2023 Q1 – 2026 Q3



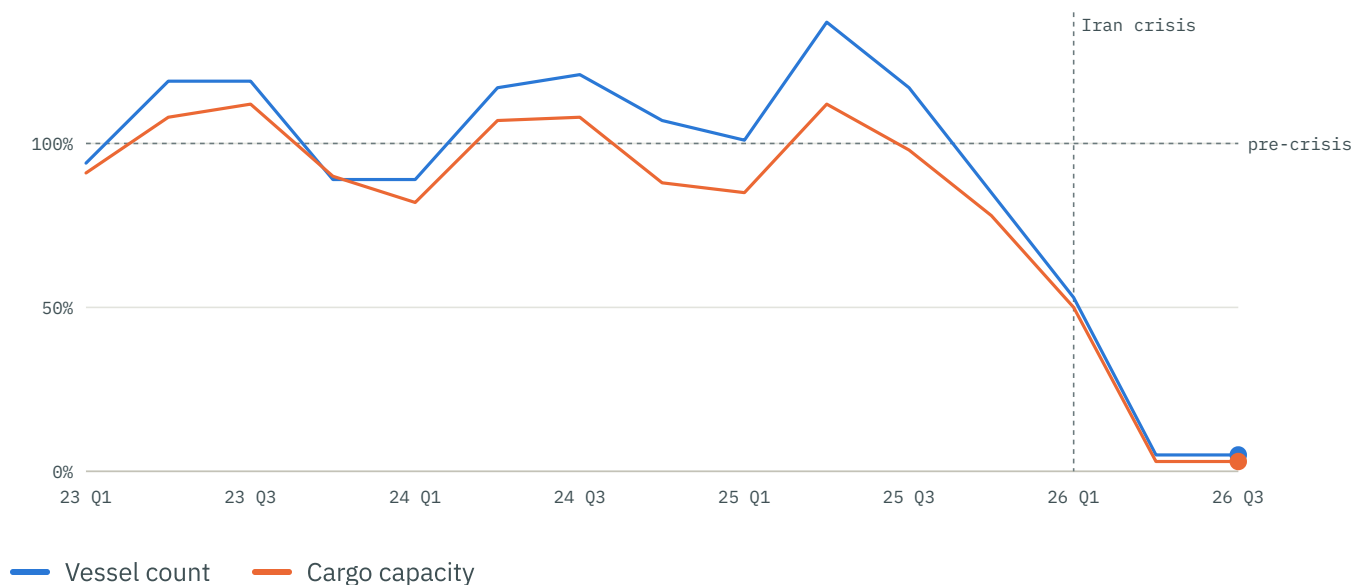
Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data, chokepoint 6, fields n_total and n_container. Marker: March 2026 crisis onset.

§ 3 Blocked, not merely thinned

A fall in vessel *count* could mean fewer, larger ships moving the same cargo. It does not: PortWatch's estimate of the aggregate cargo *capacity* of transiting container ships is at **4% of pre-crisis** — as low as the count, or lower. The few box ships still using the strait are the smaller ones. Real throughput is gone, not redistributed onto bigger tonnage.

Vessel count and cargo capacity fell together

Hormuz container traffic, indexed to the Sep–Nov 2023 average (= 100)



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data. Both series divided by their own pre-crisis mean.

WHY THIS MATTERS

If the count fell while capacity held, a count-based alarm would be a false positive. Here both lines hit the floor together.

§ 4 Two shocks, two chokepoints

The 2024 line and the 2026 line are different events at different straits – and neither one spilled into the other.

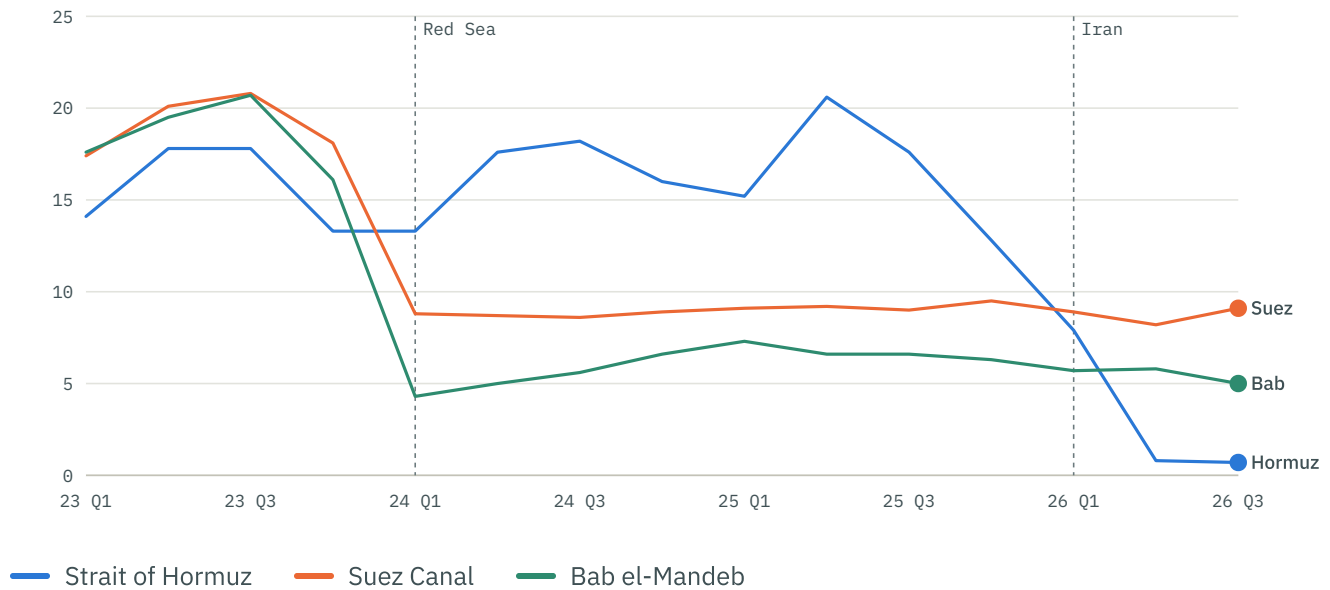
Put container transits through all three chokepoints on one axis and the picture separates cleanly. **Suez** and **Bab el-Mandeb** fall together in Q1 2024 – the Red Sea / Houthi crisis – and have held at that lower level ever since. **Hormuz** is flat through that whole period, then falls on its own in Q1–Q2 2026 – the Iran conflict.

The Red Sea route shows almost no *additional* dip in 2026: the Asia–Europe container trade had already left it, so the Iran crisis had nothing there to divert. The two

disruptions stack in cost — the Cape reroute and the Gulf closure are both live — but they are independent in the data.

Container transits per day — Hormuz vs the Red Sea chokepoints

Quarterly average, 2023 Q1 – 2026 Q3



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Chokepoints_Data, field n_container. Markers: Q1 2024 Red Sea / Houthi crisis; Q1 2026 Iran / Strait of Hormuz crisis.

§ 5 Jebel Ali goes dark

Jebel Ali (Dubai) is the Gulf's dominant container port and one of the ten busiest in the world. It sits *inside* the strait, and it tracked the chokepoint almost exactly: container port calls held at about 13 per day from 2023 through 2025, then **2.3** in July 2026 (**18% of normal**). Estimated container trade volume — imports and exports — is running at **17–22%** of pre-crisis.

Jebel Ali — container port calls per day

Quarterly average, 2023 Q1 – 2026 Q3



Source: IMF PortWatch, Daily_Ports_Data, field portcalls_container, port ID port744.

§ 6 The diversion, mapped

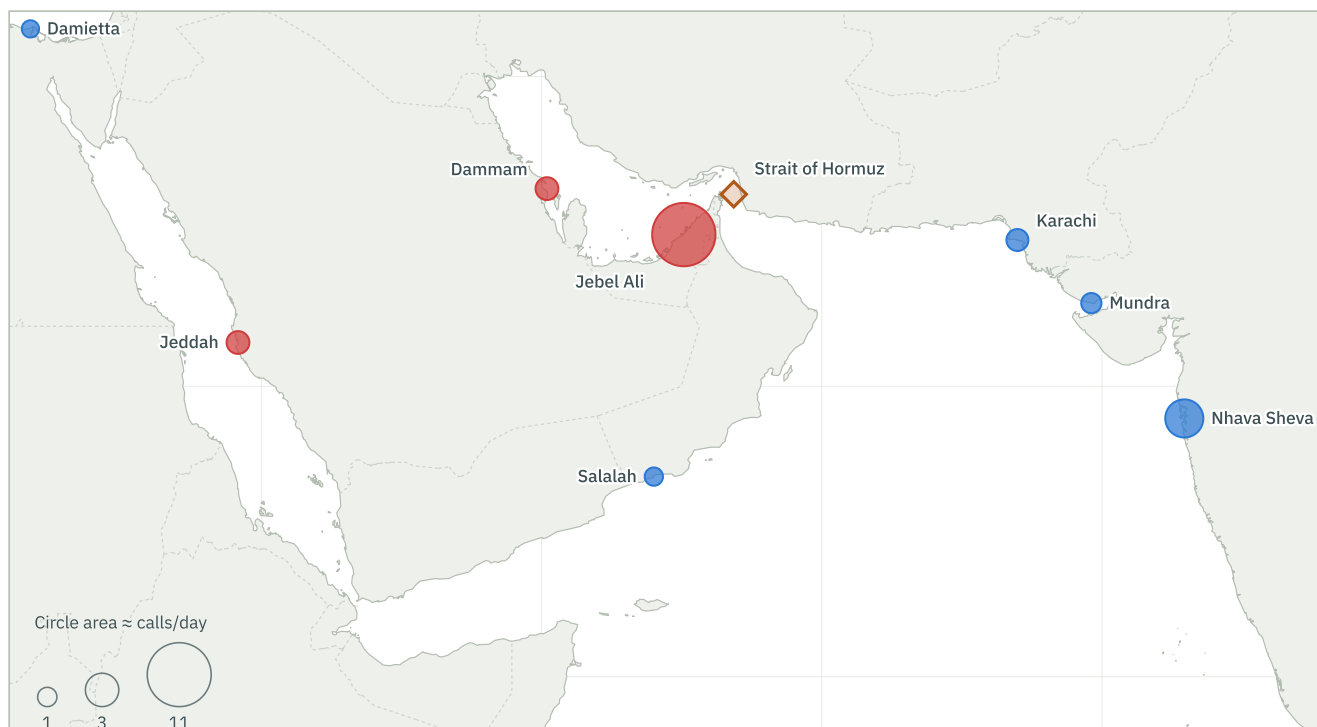
One picture of the whole reroute: the Gulf hub and the strait empty out, and the calls reappear on India's west coast, in Oman, and on Egypt's Mediterranean coast.

Every circle is a port; its area is the change in daily container port calls between the six months before the conflict and July 2026. **Blue** ports gained calls, **red** ports lost them, and the **diamond** marks the Strait of Hormuz itself, where transits — not port calls — are down about 93%.

The pattern is directional, not a scatter. The losses sit *inside* the Gulf — Jebel Ali above all. The gains are on the seaward side of the strait and along the Indian subcontinent's west coast, the shortest redirect for cargo that can no longer reach the Gulf. Saudi Arabia's Red Sea ports are red too — Bab el-Mandeb is a second drag on that coast — and the big transshipment hubs barely move.

Where container port calls were lost and gained

Change in calls per day, July 2026 vs the Sep 2025 – Feb 2026 pre-conflict window



— Container calls gained — Container calls lost — Strait of Hormuz (transits)

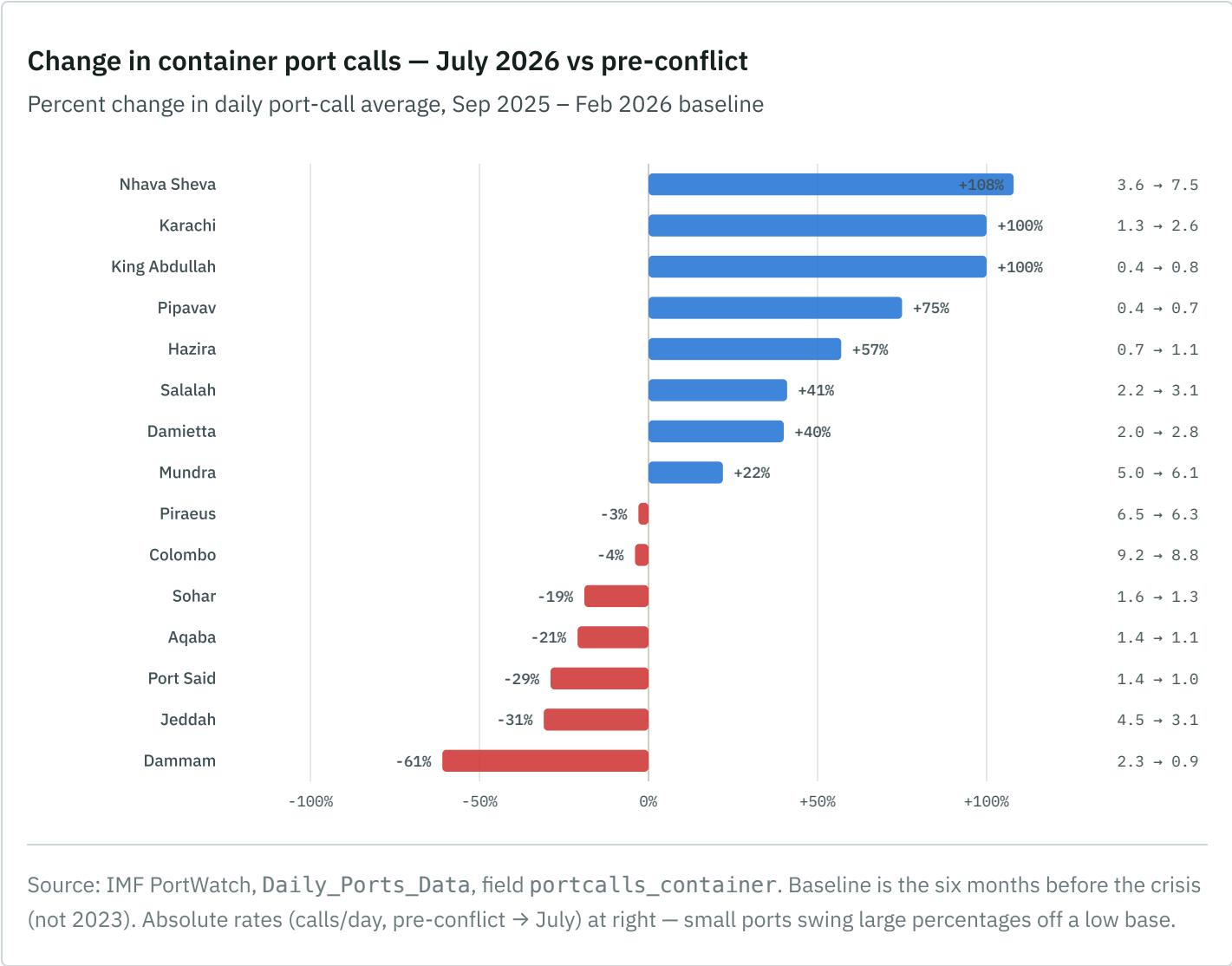
Basemap: Natural Earth 10m (public domain). Ports: IMF PortWatch Daily_Ports_Data (portcalls_container); coordinates from PortWatch's port database. Strait marker: Daily_Chokepoints_Data, chokepoint 6, n_container. Circle area is proportional to the absolute change in daily calls.

§ 7 Where the containers went

Cargo that would have moved through the Gulf has rerouted, and not to the usual transshipment hubs. Measured against the six months just before the crisis, container port calls have surged on the **Indian subcontinent's west coast** and at ports positioned *outside* the strait: Nhava Sheva +108%, Karachi +100%, Salalah +41%, Damietta +40%.

Saudi Arabia's Red Sea ports (Aqaba -21%, Port Said -29%, Jeddah -31%, Dammam -61%) are *down* — the Bab el-Mandeb disruption compounds the Gulf one there — and the mega-transshipment hubs that would normally absorb a shock (Colombo, Piraeus) are flat. This section uses the immediate pre-conflict window, not the 2023 baseline, because several of these ports grew on their own over 2023–2025.

A large percentage gain does not mean a port has room for it — §8 measures each of these ports against its own capacity ceiling.



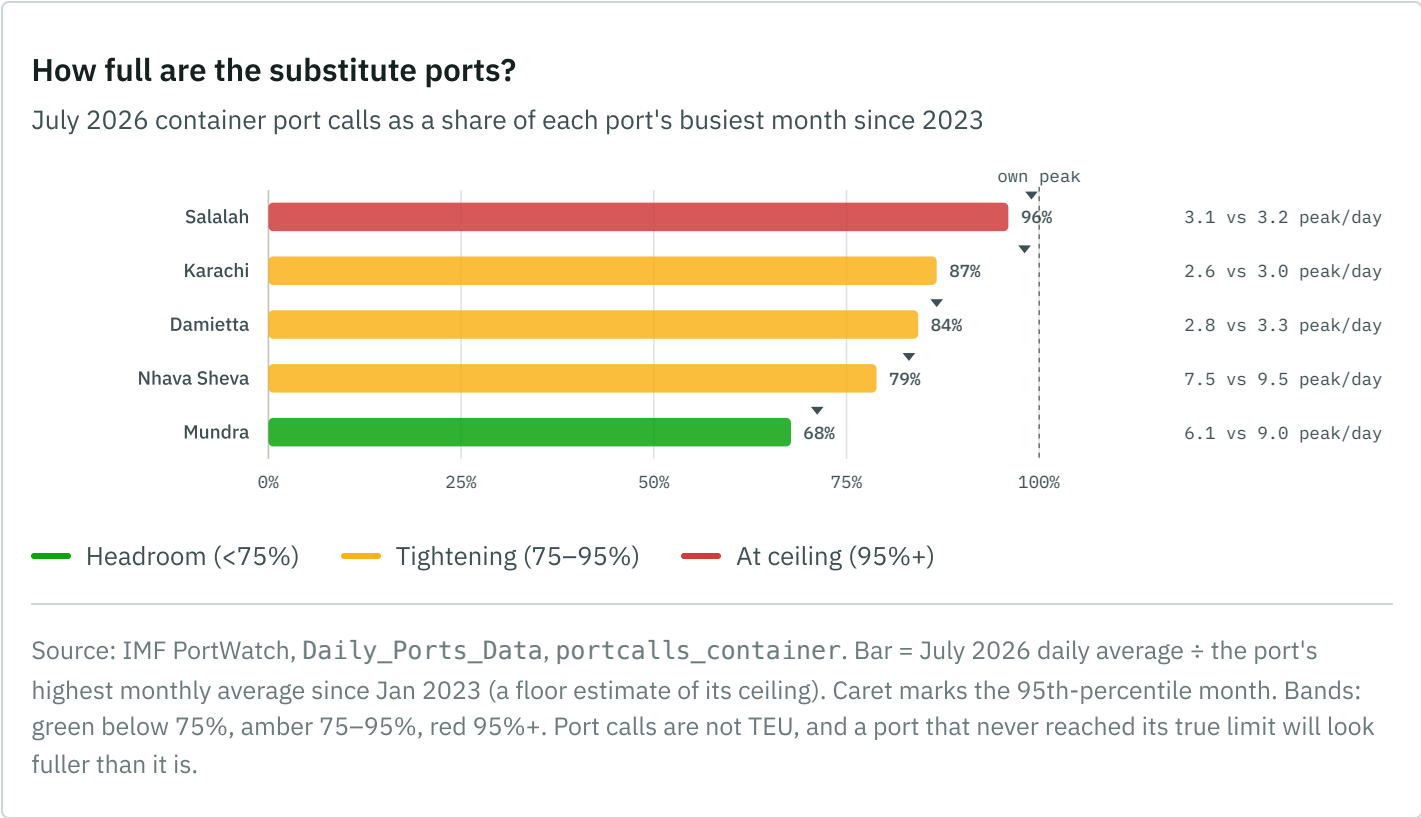
§ 8 Can the substitutes absorb it?

A port running +100% is not a port with room to spare. Against each port's own busiest month on record, most of the ports taking Gulf volume are already near their ceilings.

The reroute percentages in §7 are measured against each port's *recent* baseline, not its capacity. To read the strain, set July 2026 throughput beside the busiest calendar month that port has posted since 2023.

On that test the diverted calls are landing on ports that are mostly **already running hot**. Salalah (96%) is at the level it has ever sustained. **Nhava Sheva**, the single biggest gainer, sits at **79%** of its record month despite the +108%, and **Karachi** at **87%** of its record is effectively at the busiest level it has ever held. The one port with real slack is **Mundra** (68%).

That is the reroute's ceiling. The alternatives can hold the volume diverted so far, but the network has little headroom for a further step-down at Hormuz — and none of these routes replaces the lost Gulf capacity one-for-one.



Substitute-port loading — July 2026 vs each port's own record month						
PORT	JUL 2026 /DAY	BUSIEST MONTH	PEAK /DAY	% OF PEAK	% OF P95	READ
Salalah	3.1	Mar 2023	3.2	96%	99%	At ceiling
Karachi	2.6	Jun 2026	3.0	87%	98%	Tightening
Damietta	2.8	Aug 2023	3.3	84%	87%	Tightening
Nhava Sheva	7.5	Apr 2025	9.5	79%	83%	Tightening

PORT	JUL 2026 /DAY	BUSIEST MONTH	PEAK /DAY	% OF PEAK	% OF P95	READ
Mundra	6.1	Jan 2025	9.0	68%	71%	Headroom

§ 9 Assessment

For container shipping the Strait of Hormuz has been functionally closed since March 2026, with no recovery trend through late August. The regional network has partly re-formed around it — Indian west-coast direct calls, Salalah, and Egyptian Mediterranean transshipment are the load-bearing alternatives — at a fraction of the lost volume, over longer distances, and (§8) into ports that are mostly already near their own operating ceilings. This is a distinct shock from the still-unresolved Red Sea diversion; the two now run in parallel.

PortWatch measures vessel movements, not their causes: the March 2026 break coincides with the reported Strait of Hormuz crisis, but the data attests to the shipping outcome. Every figure is measured against a fixed 2023 quarter; because Gulf throughput was within ~10% of that level right through 2025, the reference choice does not move the finding.

Quarterly figures — Strait of Hormuz and Jebel Ali, containers				
QUARTER	HORMUZ TOTAL /DAY	HORMUZ CONTAINER/DAY	HORMUZ CONTAINER CAPACITY/DAY	JEBEL ALI CALLS/DAY
23 Q1	83	14.1	412,629	12.9
23 Q2	101	17.8	485,319	13.9
23 Q3	102	17.8	506,808	13.2
23 Q4	82	13.3	406,482	13.1
24 Q1	80	13.3	371,734	13.2
24 Q2	104	17.6	484,477	11.9
24 Q3	100	18.2	488,478	13.0
24 Q4	81	16.0	397,086	14.3
25 Q1	76	15.2	381,430	14.5
25 Q2	102	20.6	503,077	14.0

QUARTER	HORMUZ TOTAL / DAY	HORMUZ CONTAINER / DAY	HORMUZ CONTAINER CAPACITY / DAY	JEBEL ALI CALLS / DAY
25 Q3	93	17.6	443,795	14.0
25 Q4	71	12.8	353,032	13.5
26 Q1	46	7.9	226,275	8.8
26 Q2	8	0.8	15,395	1.1
26 Q3	8	0.7	11,537	2.0

§ Method & provenance

Every figure in this brief is reproducible from a local database built by the open-source **logjam** tool and a single generator script. Nothing is hand-transcribed.

DATA SOURCE

IMF PortWatch (portwatch.imf.org) — daily maritime activity estimated from satellite AIS on ~90,000 ships, via the UN Global Platform. Free public use with attribution. Backfill covers 1 Jan 2023 – 23 Aug 2026.

WHAT THE NUMBERS ARE

`n_total` / `n_container` / `n_tanker` are counts of vessel transits by class at chokepoint 6. `capacity_container` is the estimated aggregate cargo capacity of transiting container ships. `import_container` / `export_container` are PortWatch's modelled trade-volume estimates — directional, not measured TEU.

BASELINE

Chokepoint transits, capacity, the comparison chart, and Jebel Ali use a fixed **September–November 2023** window, matching the sibling Red Sea briefs — Hormuz throughput was within ~10% of that level every quarter through 2025, so the immediate pre-conflict period gives the same result. The **map (§6) and reroute analysis (§7) use September 2025 – February 2026** instead, because several candidate ports grew on their own over 2023–2025 and a 2023 comparison would conflate that growth with the diversion. Percent-of-normal = current value ÷ baseline mean.

“CURRENT” MONTH

July 2026. PortWatch revises its most recent ~2 weeks upward as satellite data lands, so August 2026 was still settling at generation time.

TWO CRISES

The 2023 Red Sea / Houthi crisis and the 2026 Iran / Strait of Hormuz crisis are separate events at separate chokepoints. The cross-chokepoint chart (§4) plots `n_container` for Hormuz, Suez, and Bab el-Mandeb on one axis; the Suez and Horn briefs cover the Red Sea side.

REROUTE ANALYSIS

Candidate substitute ports (Indian west coast, Omani and Red Sea ports, Mediterranean and South Asian transshipment hubs) compared on `portcalls_container`, July 2026 vs Sep 2025 – Feb 2026. Ranked by percent change; absolute rates shown alongside because small ports swing large percentages off a low base.

ABSORPTION / CAPACITY (§8)

PortWatch publishes no berth or design capacity for ports, so each port's ceiling is proxied by its **busiest calendar month on record since January 2023** (highest monthly average of `portcalls_container`). §8 reads July 2026 against that peak and against the port's 95th-percentile month (a “sustained” level). Bands: <75% headroom, 75–95% tightening, ≥95% at ceiling. This is a **floor estimate** of capacity — a port that never reached its true limit in this window looks fuller than it is — and it counts vessel calls, not TEU. For a port whose busiest month falls *after* March 2026 (e.g. Karachi), that peak already reflects diverted traffic, so the headroom read is conservative: the port has shown it can handle at least that much.

MAP

Basemap is Natural Earth 10m land and national boundary lines (public domain), clipped to the region, simplified, and projected with Web Mercator in the browser — no map tiles, no network at render time. Port coordinates come from PortWatch's own port database. Each circle's **area** is proportional to the absolute change in daily container port calls (same window as §7); the Strait of Hormuz is a fixed diamond because its metric is transits, not port calls. Build the geographic assets with `uv run --with shapely --with httpx python scripts/reports/build_geo_assets.py`.

REPRODUCE

Clone github.com/ubeast/logjam, backfill the database to 2023, then `uv run python scripts/reports/hormuz_container_2026.py`. Full method in `docs/METHODOLOGY.md`.

Limitations

- PortWatch measures throughput (vessels moving), not queue length or berth dwell time. This brief cannot say how long individual ships waited.
- The data attests to the shipping outcome, not the cause. The March 2026 onset coincides with the reported Strait of Hormuz crisis; causation is not established here.

- Trade-volume and capacity fields are model estimates, not manifest data.
- All comparisons are versus a fixed 2023 quarter; Gulf throughput was stable from 2023 through early 2026, so the choice is not sensitive, but every figure is “versus 2023.”
- The reroute set only includes ports named in the tool's substitution list; an unlisted beneficiary would be missed.
- The §8 capacity read uses each port's busiest month since 2023 as a ceiling proxy — a floor estimate of true capacity — and counts vessel calls, not container volume; a port taking larger ships absorbs more than its call count implies.

Michael Schertz · built with [logjam](#), an open-source logistics bottleneck & opportunity identifier
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